This mechanical world view is echoed in the Delhi Master Plan of 1962 which proclaimed that ‘there is undesirable mixing of land-uses almost everywhere in the city’. Just as the government had the right to control the economy through licences, it also had the right to tell people where to live and where to work. The problem is that such an approach cannot create a living ecosystem. New industrial cities like Durgapur never took off, and today’s successful cities are still those with British-era roots. Even Chandigarh, the expensive poster-child of master-planning, has generated little of economic or cultural value after half a century of existence. Much of its apparent ‘cleanliness’ comes from simply having left no space for the poor within city limits. It remains a sterile and heavily subsidized city of tax-consuming bureaucrats that encourages neither entrepreneurship nor tax-generating jobs despite being the capital of two prosperous states. To the extent that the city has shown any energy at all, it comes from the evolving suburb of Mohali rather than from Corbusier’s Chandigarh. Nehru had wanted Chandigarh to be the symbol of India’s future. Instead, the face of twenty-first-century India is a city that is chaotic, unplanned, infuriating but undeniably dynamic: Gurgaon.

LAISSEZ-FAIRE CITY

Gurgaon lies to the south of Delhi and, according to legend, is said to have belonged to Dronacharya who taught martial arts to the Pandav and Kaurav cousins in the Mahabharat. Indeed, the name Gurgaon literally means the ‘village of the teacher’. Despite its proximity to Delhi, however, the settlement of Gurgaon was never particularly large. Its population was estimated at a mere 3990 in 1881 and nearby towns like Rewari and Farrukhnagar had much larger populations. The *Gazetteer* of 1883–84 tells us that the British used Gurgaon as a district headquarters and that the town consisted of a small market (Sadar Bazaar), public offices, dwellings of European residents and a settlement called Jacombpura named after a former Deputy Commissioner[20]. An old road connected Gurgaon to Delhi via Mehrauli. The road is now the arterial MG Road, but the contours of the